

Experiential Marketing

How Event Design Shapes Brand Perception

Elise Gardner

How Laufey Mastered the Art of Connection

Meet Laufey: A Grammy-winning Icelandic-Chinese artist who knows *precisely* how to connect with her fans in more ways than just her music. August 24 marks “[A Very Laufey Day](#),” a day when Laufey’s fans—known as ‘Lauvers’—come together all over the world to participate in activities.¹ Every year, Laufey organizes an itinerary inspired by her music and invites fans to participate and share their adventures online.



Activities like visiting coffee shops, thrifting, and getting froyo connect fans to their local communities and Laufey’s online fanbase. These activities have become a fond tradition that unify fans and keep them engaged with her music.

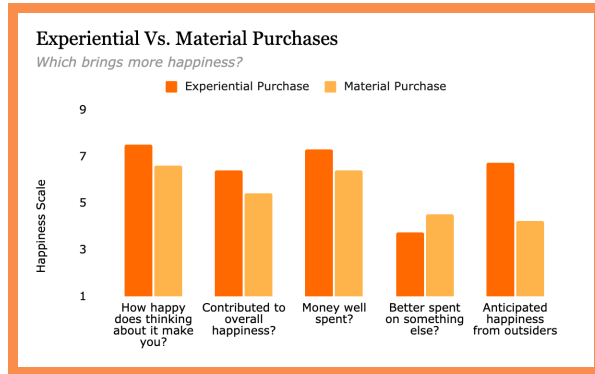
Connecting Through Experience

By creating meaningful experiences for fans rather than simply promoting her music, Laufey demonstrates the power of experiential marketing. “A Very Laufey Day” shows how emotionally engaging experiences create lasting connections between brand and customer. As consumers increasingly value experiences over possessions, businesses that prioritize emotion will thrive in the economy.

Laufey used the same principle that makes brands successful today: emotional connection. This paper explores how brands use experiential marketing to build connection, the rise of the experience economy, the types of experiential marketing, how event design shapes perception, and strategies for creating memorable experiences and loyalty.

The Rise of Experiential Value

People are beginning to value experiences over possessions. A study by [Van Boven and Gilovich](#) shows how connection creates more satisfaction than consumption. Study participants reported greater happiness spending money on experiences rather than on things.²



[Van Boven, L., & Gilovich, T. \(2003\). "To Do or to Have? That Is the Question." *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*](#)

Why do experiences make people so much happier? It's all about connection. Connection to peers, identity, and the world is what brings us happiness.

The Experience Hierarchy

To understand how experiences differ in their impact, researchers in Brigham Young University's Experience Design and Management department identified a framework called the **Experience Hierarchy**. In their article "[From ordinary to extraordinary: A framework of experience types](#)," they outline four categories of experience: **ordinary**, **memorable**, **meaningful**, and **transformative**.³

Ordinary experiences are everyday moments—like eating breakfast. Memorable experiences evoke emotion, meaningful experiences bring insight, and transformative experiences create change.

Understanding the experience hierarchy helps brands create interactions that move from ordinary to meaningful.

The Experience Economy

As experiences grow in significance, their economic value also shifts.

Experiences become powerful when they move past a service and become a memorable moment. They are becoming their own category in the economy, alongside commodities, goods, and services.

Walt Disney Co. once dominated the experience economy, but many brands now use experiential marketing. In the *Harvard Business Review*, [Pine and Gilmore](#) emphasized that the experience economy is no longer limited to entertainment companies.⁴

"Today the concept of selling experiences is spreading beyond theaters and theme parks."

Experiences are intentionally staged, carefully thought-out, and perfectly executed. Stores like IKEA have used the concept of experiences to elevate their brand. They turn furniture shopping into an enjoyable experience.

Experiences stick to a theme, invoke emotion, and eliminate bad cues. IKEA reinforces its theme by tagging products in Swedish and offering Swedish meatballs. They turn their stores into homes, helping customers visualize comfort. They even make shopping easier for parents by providing free daycare.

Just as IKEA does, many companies are realizing that creating emotional experiences is key to shaping brand

perception. Even if companies don't base their business on selling experiences, they can use experiential marketing strategies to boost how consumers perceive their brand.

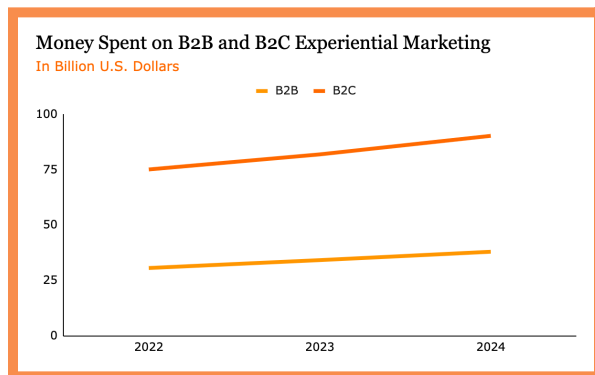
This focus on emotional engagement plays out differently depending on whether brands are targeting consumers or other businesses.

Types of Experiential Marketing

B2B (business-to-business) experiential marketing occurs when one business delivers an experience to another, generating profit and exposure.

Laufey used B2B marketing this August 24, teaming up with Yogurtland locations worldwide to launch her very own fro-yo flavor, "A Berry Laufey Day." Yogurtland helped create an experience for Lauvers.

B2C (business-to-consumer) experiential marketing provides consumers with experiences. Laufey's "A Very Laufey Day" exemplifies effective B2C marketing, transforming her brand into an interactive experience that deepens engagement and reinforces loyalty.



Data from [Statista](#)

The figure shows that spending on both B2C⁵ and B2B⁶ experiential marketing increased in 2023 and was predicted to rise further in 2024. The figure shows just how popular experiential marketing is becoming. Spending on B2C experiential marketing is much higher, highlighting the importance of brands building strong connections with their customers.

Event Design Shapes Brand Perception

Brand perception refers to people's thoughts and feelings about a company or business, shaped by their interactions with it. Memories and associations also help form perception.

Experiential marketing has the power to create connection, powerful emotions, and even change. [Urdea and Constantin](#), in their article on experiential marketing⁷, say it best:

"A successful marketing event is marked by the power to spread feelings of entertainment, curiosity, and joyfulness among the customers."

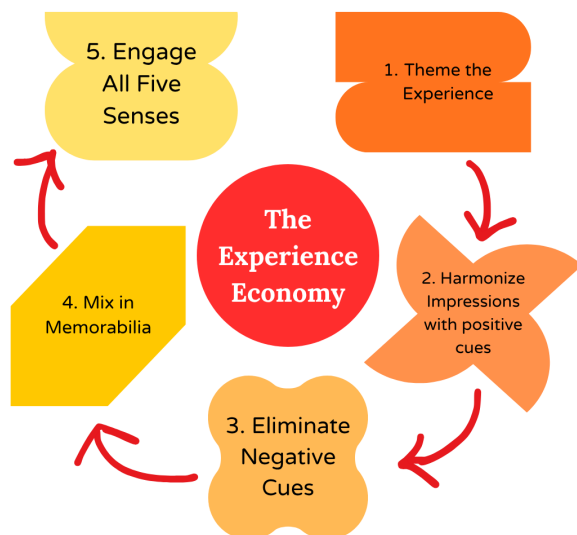
Events that evoke excitement link that emotion to the brand.

Taylor Swift's "The Eras Tour" created experiences for fans within every different era. She effectively tuned into fans' nostalgia for her past songs and excitement about her new ones. This concert series became a fan favorite and brought Swift publicity.

Chen, Singh, and others in their study on event marketing claim that “unique enjoyable experiences translate to fun, which then become memorable experiences that motivate attendees to attend future events.” Creating memorable experiences will always keep people coming back for more.⁸ There is a reason Disneyland is an annual tradition for many families.

How Brands Create Experiences: Strategies for effective experiential marketing

A memorable experience, according to Pine and Gilmore, is defined by these five steps⁴:



Theme Brand Events

An event should stay true to the brand's values when developing its theme. Brand values create consistency and customer loyalty. For example, Nike supports athleticism through experiences like 5Ks and fun runs.

Red Bull takes this concept to a new level. Their slogan is “Red Bull Gives You Wiings,” which leads people to associate the brand with adventure, performance, and energy. Red Bull took those emotions and created Red Bull Rampage: a high-stakes mountain biking competition held at Zion National Park. People watching these events feel emotions such as excitement, fear, and anticipation—right on brand for Red Bull.

Create Positive Cues

Positive cues are elements of the experience that must be incorporated fully into the theme. Themed restaurants should align food, decor, and employee interactions with the brand.

Brooker's Founding Flavors, an ice cream shop based in Utah, effectively incorporates positive cues into its 18th-century Founding Fathers theme. They name their flavors after the American Revolution, decorate the space to reflect that century, and dress employees in colonial attire. Brooker's knows precisely how to incorporate positive cues.

Eliminate Negative Cues

Just as a company should incorporate positive cues, it should also eliminate negative ones to fully stage an experience.

Brooker's uses their decor to eliminate negative cues. Rather than using a regular trash can, they turn it into a barrel to match the decor. Instead of an industrial drinking fountain, they use a well. These things fully immerse customers into their theme.

Mix in Memorabilia

Like tourists buying souvenirs, brand events should include keepsakes. This souvenir, of course, should go along with their brand theme.

Leaving people with a physical token of the event can help them remember their experience long after it ends. This token can be as simple as a photo taken during the event. Photo booths are an effective way to send customers home with memorabilia while capturing memories and emotions associated with the event.

Photo booths are an effective way to send customers home with memorabilia as it perfectly captures the emotions they felt.

Engage All 5 Senses

A theme should engage all five senses: touch, sound, sight, smell, and taste. When all senses are engaged, people have become fully immersed in an experience. The more senses that an event engages, the more memorable it becomes.

Incorporating Experiential Marketing

Event marketing is a powerful tool for creating buzz around a brand, but it can go beyond parties.

[Mailchimp](#), a popular marketing platform, recognized two other experiential marketing strategies: **guerrilla marketing campaigns** and **pop-up shops**.⁹

Guerrilla Marketing Campaigns

Guerrilla campaigns are a surprise to the public. It typically includes challenges for people to participate in. These campaigns should always keep the target audience in mind. Where does their audience spend their time? If they're young adults, try college towns.

The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints uses guerrilla marketing tactics for its #LightTheWorld Giving Machines. Their giving machines appear in public places like malls, and give people an opportunity to interact with their service.

For experiential marketing to be effective, it must include an opportunity for interaction between the business and the customer. Guerrilla marketing effectively incorporates interaction, making it a good experiential strategy.

Pop-up shops

Much like guerrilla marketing, pop-up shops utilize public spaces to connect with consumers—this time, in the form of temporary retail spaces for direct interaction.

Glossier, a popular makeup brand, utilizes pop-up shops all around the world. Customers can sample products, take photos, and share their experiences online.

Using Social Media

Using social media to advertise an event is an effective way to build anticipation. In an experience-based study, [Gilovich](#) found that anticipating experiences helps create excitement.¹⁰ When there is excitement

around an event, social media buzz reaches a broad audience.

Social media can do more than promote events. Companies can use online platforms for customers to share pictures and videos of their experience, creating publicity. Technology can also be the platform for the event itself. Laufey used her online presence to connect fans globally, making experiences accessible and individual.

The COVID-19 pandemic accelerated online experiential marketing, and reaching customers virtually remains a key strategy today.

“In the future the most powerful, compelling and useful experiences will be those that fuse the real and the virtual.”

– Joseph B. Pine, *Exploring the future of the “Experience Economy”* ¹¹

Even as people spend more of their time online, they still crave interaction. That’s what makes experiential marketing so powerful! Balancing physical interaction and the future of virtual interaction is what makes the perfect experiential marketing strategy.

The Power of Experience

Whether online or in person, experiential marketing succeeds because it turns interactions into emotional connections.

Experiences are more than just a marketing strategy—they’re a means of connection, inspiration, and emotion. Laufey didn’t just advertise her music; she

created a memory her fans can live in. This is what transforms a brand: when it becomes more than a company and becomes part of people’s lives.

About the Author

Elise Gardner is a Pre-Business Major at Brigham Young University-Provo, applying for the Experience Design and Management program. She is passionate about how experiences shape human perception and connection. Elise was inspired to write about experiential marketing because of her love for meaningful moments and the memories they have given her. She hopes to pursue a career in event design and management, creating experiences that bring people together. Outside of her studies, Elise enjoys trying new foods, hobbies, and adventures.



Connect with her on [LinkedIn](#).

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